was the first large acquisition that Ratan would make, pursuing a policy that he saw as the only route for the group to achieve faster growth. A leading Indian magazine described the verve of Tata Tea in taking on the world champion thus: ‘A battle is brewing in the global tea industry. In one corner is Unilever, the Mike Tyson of the tea industry with a powerful punch that can reach out to all corners of the globe. In the other corner is a surprise new contender that has just graduated into the heavyweight category: Tata Tea.’

Regarding being in competition with Unilever, Krishna Kumar, who was no pushover, said, ‘We expect Unilever to be aggressive. But we believe we are much more focused in tea than Unilever.’

On 28 February 2000, Tata Tea and the shareholders of the Tetley Group announced the signing of an agreement clinching the deal. It was agreed that the Indian entity, through a 100 per cent subsidiary in the UK, would make a formal offer for acquiring the entire shareholding of the Tetley Group. The cost for the worldwide Tetley Tea business, including the private-label tea component in the US, was pegged at £271 million or €443 million. It was the largest overseas acquisition by an Indian company until then.

The acquisition caused waves in London’s business circles and elsewhere. The *South China Morning Post* wrote: ‘Now, nine years after economic liberalisation flung the doors open to foreign competitors, they are cheering one of their own for striking a blow for corporate India by breaching a foreign bastion.’

Ratan was ebullient. He was quoted by the same newspaper as saying triumphantly that it was a ‘great signal for global industry by Indian industry’. Krishna Kumar could also not contain his excitement and ‘gloated’ to the same newspaper, saying, ‘Millions of tea bags will carry the Tata name into millions of Western homes.’

The acquisition was significant for many reasons. It was the first big foray by an Indian company into the UK, a country that held significant meaning for both India and the Tata Group. Tetley was owned by a country whose association with India often evoked unpleasant historical memories. As for the Tatas, though both the sons of the founder had been knighted, JRD, had refused the honour as he had no love lost for the UK. He had openly criticized British policies and was ‘terribly anxious to see them out’.